Solomon and the First Temple

1 Kings 3; 6; 8; 11

The big idea: Solomon asked God for wisdom, built the temple on Mount Moriah, and saw the glory of God fill it. Then the wisest king let his heart drift after other gods, and the kingdom split. Jesus is greater than Solomon: the wisdom of God and the true temple, raised on the third day.

Before you meet: Read

1 Kings 3:3–28 | 1 Kings 8:1–30 | 1 Kings 11:1–13 | Matthew 12:42; John 2:19–21

Open (5 minutes)

If you could ask God for one thing and know he would give it, what would you ask for?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Give your servant therefore an understanding _____ to govern your people, that I may discern between good and evil." *(1 Kings 3:9)*

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of _____." *(Proverbs 9:10)*

"A cloud filled the house of the LORD… for the _____ of the LORD filled the house of the LORD." *(1 Kings 8:10–11)*

"Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot _____ you; how much less this house that I have built!" *(1 Kings 8:27)*

"For when Solomon was old his wives turned away his _____ after other gods." *(1 Kings 11:4)*

"Something _____ than Solomon is here." *(Matthew 12:42)*

Discuss

1. Solomon asked for an understanding mind and not for wealth or long life. What does his request teach you about prayer? *1 Kings 3:5–14; James 1:5*

2. The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom. How is that different from simply being smart or successful? *Proverbs 9:10*

3. Solomon said heaven cannot contain God, yet God put his name in the temple. How can both be true? *1 Kings 8:27–30*

4. Solomon broke all three limits for kings: horses, wives, and gold. Which of power, sex, or money pulls hardest on hearts today? *Deuteronomy 17:16–17; 1 Kings 10–11*

5. Solomon's heart turned away slowly, when he was old. What helps a heart stay faithful over a lifetime? *1 Kings 11:4, 9*

6. Jesus called his body the temple. What does it mean for you that God now meets his people in Jesus, and not in a building? *John 2:19–21; 4:21–24; 1 Peter 2:4–5*

Apply this week

Name one decision you are facing and pray James 1:5 over it each day this week. Read one chapter of Proverbs a day, matching today's date. Then name one small compromise that, repeated over time, could turn your heart, and bring it to God.

Memory verse

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is insight."

Proverbs 9:10

Pray

Ask God for wisdom for the decisions in front of you. Confess anything slowly drawing your heart away from him. Thank Jesus that he is greater than Solomon, the wisdom of God and the true temple, and that he holds on to the people he saves.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 15

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Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read 1 Kings 3:5–14 aloud together. Then read 1 Kings 8:22–30.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the From Tent to Temple table and the King's Law chart in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 16 (1 Kings 12, 17–19; 2 Kings 17).

Main points to land

1. Solomon asked for wisdom to serve God's people, and God gave it generously, along with riches and honor (1 Kings 3:9–13).
2. Biblical wisdom begins with the fear of the LORD. It is skill for living that comes from knowing God (Proverbs 9:10).
3. The temple, begun in 966 BC on Mount Moriah, was filled with God's glory. Even so, heaven itself cannot contain God (1 Kings 6:1; 8:10–11, 27).
4. Solomon broke the king's limits and let his heart drift after other gods, and the kingdom split after his death (Deuteronomy 17:16–17; 1 Kings 11:4, 11–13).
5. Jesus is greater than Solomon: the wisdom of God, the true temple raised on the third day, and the King whose heart never turned (Matthew 12:42; John 2:19–21; 1 Corinthians 1:30).

Answer key (Observe)

1. mind
2. wisdom
3. glory
4. contain
5. heart
6. greater

Questions people will ask

If Solomon was so wise, how could he fall so far?
Wisdom is a gift, but it does not run on autopilot. Solomon disobeyed God's clear limits and married many women who worshiped other gods, and slowly his heart followed them (1 Kings 11:1–4). Knowledge never guarantees faithfulness. That is why we need a King whose heart never turns, and a Spirit who keeps changing ours.

Did Solomon end up saved or lost?

The Bible does not tell us clearly, and we should not claim more than it says. What it does say is sobering: his heart was not wholly true to God (1 Kings 11:4). Use the question to point the group to Jesus, who holds on to the people he saves (John 10:28).

Why did God allow so much gold and so many wives if they were against his law?

God did not approve; Deuteronomy 17 forbade it. God often lets people walk in the direction they choose, and Scripture records it honestly so we learn from it. Solomon's riches were a gift (1 Kings 3:13), but he used them to break God's limits, and the consequences followed.

Do Christians need a temple today?

No building is now the place where God meets his people. Jesus is the true temple (John 2:19–21), and believers together are being built into God's house (1 Peter 2:4–5). We gather in church buildings for worship, but God meets us in Christ wherever we call on him in spirit and truth (John 4:23–24).

Closing prayer

Father, you gave Solomon wisdom and filled your house with glory. Give us wisdom for the decisions before us, and keep our hearts from drifting. Forgive us for the small compromises that turn us away from you. Thank you for Jesus, greater than Solomon, the wisdom of God and the true temple, who rose on the third day and holds us fast. Amen.